

Episode 128: Once Upon a Time... 73 – 1994 Part 7 – *Dragon Ball Z* Blues

The other day, I actually bought reading glasses! When I went shopping at Muji in Ikebukuro Seibu, they were selling lightweight, affordable, somewhat fashionable ones, and I couldn't help picking them up.

Yes, actually I'm developing presbyopia. Well, not just me—quite a lot of anime industry colleagues in their 40s are getting presbyopia at considerable pace. Man, presbyopia comes on suddenly!

I noticed it about three years ago on a certain day. Somehow I couldn't instantly shift eye focus well anymore, and it became difficult to focus on close things. Initially, I didn't realise that was presbyopia. When I happened to discuss "my eyes lately..." with work colleagues of the same generation, they said "Ah, that's presbyopia." Shock!

Well, that's why I finally bought them, but man, frustrating as it is, these are great. I can see incredibly well. At that moment, it felt like one era quietly ended within me (cry).

Now then.

Continuing the 1994 story.

Returning from the Manila business trip, my next job was waiting. My second theatrical work of the year: *Dragon Ball Z Movie: Super Warriors Defeated!! I'm the One Who'll Win*. Director was Ueda Yoshihiro. Animation Director was Yamamuro-san continuing from the previous work, and Art Director was also Tokushige-san, same as before.

My fourth *Dragon Ball Z*. Writing this might get me in trouble, but I was actually getting slightly tired of *Dragon Ball Z*.

Sure, it's theatrical work after all, so under the director I was working hard on the project to have people watch something even slightly more enjoyable, to leave something even slightly better—that didn't change. But honestly, the stories just weren't interesting (wry laugh). The inevitable flow of repetitive developments each time, common to long-running works, was unavoidable, and while I tried various approaches, stories that didn't change much became inescapable.

This story had Broly from the previous theatrical version appearing before Goten and Gohan in a new way... I think... probably... (sweat) ...That's about all I can remember—it's already faded in memory.

For better or worse, one instalment of the so-called "Toei Manga Festival." When I think about it, receiving theatrical work is a luxurious, inexcusable complaint, but for me it was work while holding some dilemma of not being able to fully get into it.

Still, I remember the staff room being quite fun, centered on Director Ueda and Animation Director Yamamuro. I remember it as a staff room where laughter never ceased. The schedule itself didn't fall terribly behind either—it felt like we created it with a "reasonably tough" atmosphere. Everyone including me had gotten used to making *Dragon Ball Z* of this volume.

I joined around Golden Week, and completion was late June.

Then summer. After resting somewhat leisurely, two projects came to me from late August. First, one theatrical work: *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon S*. And one mysterious video work titled *Warriors of Erosion*.

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon S was a side story to the TV series that began that year following *Sailor Moon R*. A theatrical version visualising a story written specifically by original creator Takeuchi Naoko.

And *Warriors of Erosion* was apparently a video work commissioned by some religious organisation. This seemed potentially quite interesting.

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